up with didn’t have quite the balance I’d hoped for and our first season wasn’t particularly successful. It also didn’t help that I wasn’t able to play the first seven games because of injury.

Happily, one of the players we did manage to pick was Lasith Malinga. I was keen to have him at any cost as I was sure he would be a handy option for this format, and he has proved to be an excellent performer in Twenty20. Mind you, no one bowls quite like Malinga. With his low, slingy action, it’s almost as if the umpire becomes the sightscreen. I remember an occasion in Sri Lanka when Malinga was bowling to me with a white ball and I had to ask the umpire to remove his white hat, because I was losing the ball against it! Unfortunately for us, Malinga wasn’t able to play the entire first season owing to a knee injury.

After the Mumbai Indians failed to make the semi-finals in the first two seasons, we were determined to put in a better performance in 2010. Mrs Nita Ambani was personally involved from the beginning of the season and this time we began our preparations weeks before the season started. We had a two-day bonding camp at the Waterstones Club in Mumbai and enjoyed getting to know each other. Mrs Ambani was present on both days and the players enjoyed interacting with her. The youngsters in the team mixed with the senior players and I remember that Zaheer Khan, Harbhajan and I were asked a series of questions by the other players about our careers and our lives as Indian cricketers. It was interesting to learn that Zaheer found it very difficult to adjust to the Mumbai lifestyle after coming from the relatively smaller town of Ahmednagar and I was particularly fascinated by Harbhajan’s stories about his childhood while growing up in Punjab. We played a variety of sports, including table tennis, squash and water polo, but no cricket.

The camp worked brilliantly and that season we finally did ourselves justice and were the team to beat throughout the competition. Unfortunately, I got injured while catching a ball in the slips in the semi-final, splitting the webbing between my fingers on my right hand. I had to have six stitches and couldn’t hold the bat properly and most people who saw the injury felt I wouldn’t make the final against the Chennai Super Kings, led by MS Dhoni. I was determined to take part, however.

On the morning of the final I tried having an injection to numb the injured area, which I thought would help me hold the bat. I had also had some special gloves made, with added protection for the injury, but it